Omar and the Wizard

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Omar had to stand exceptionally close to the mirror to look clearly, but after a good long while he was sure; there was more silver in his hair than there was brown. With a disappointed grunt, he left his bathroom and moved to the nearest window of his grand bedroom, looking out at Aultur; it was about an hour shy of midday and the streets were bustling. Though his house was higher up on the hills and looking down on the town, he could still make out the blurry shapes hurrying to and fro the central market, buying beautiful bunches of fruit and fowl.

It seemed smaller now. Omar wasn't quite sure how long ago it was that Aultur started looking so little; he was fairly certain nobody had come along and shrunken it, and if they had Omar was quite sure he would be the first person they came to.

Amid the rushing blurs, Omar made out a red shape making its way up the steps leading to his house.

Omar stepped away from his window and consulted his wardrobe, quickly throwing on a comfortable outfit; a frilly white shirt with a blue long coat over it, as well as thick brown pants. With bare feet, Omar slipped into a pair of comfortable shoes, and before starting downstairs, reluctantly put on his rounded glasses.

Leaving his room he turned down a hall, down a spiraling staircase, and another hall before he made it to his foyer, opening the door to reveal a young red-haired woman as she was about to knock, "Hello, Ezilia."

"Hello Mr. Odrin. I was wondering, if he'd arrived yet?" Ezilia asked, rubbing her hands together nervously.

Omar smiled softly, "Not yet, I'm afraid. I told you, if he does I'll send him to you, rest assured."

With a sigh, Ezilia smiled back, "I know, I'm just jittery. I'll be patient. Mother and I are making scones, I'll bring you some when they're ready."

"That'd be lovely, thank you."

"Thank *you*." Ezilia laughed and started back down the stairs, "I'll see you later."

Omar shut the door and turned to enter his living room; often referred to as his "Trophy Room" by friends and guests. Unquestionably due to the embellished decorating Omar had done with so many trinkets and souvenirs throughout his travels and adventures.

He smiled and looked fondly over them. They ranged from just about any form of material object you could imagine: a golden helmet from a real knight of Eldermoore placed

neatly on the bookshelf, a nearly full loaf of Idlebread from the Sealy Dwarves sat gingerly on the coffee table (delicious, filling, fairly well nibbled at over these many years, and still as clean as the day it was made), a coiled horn from a Wenterbeast took up a large chunk of the fireplace mantle, and oh so many swords of all shapes and sizes were scattered about the room. Many were hung up on the walls assorted with a rich variety of weapons, there were more in the corner in an umbrella holder, the rest could be found propped up against walls and furniture.

Omar chuckled to himself, recounting the stories that came with each of his collection items, and kindled a small fire in the fireplace before sitting back on one of his luxurious velvet chairs. Whogen, an old friend, had gifted Omar a rather sizeable tome to work through, about a revenant king and his friend death (the book says "friend" but the relationship reads far more complicated than any friendship ought to be). Omar had been reading this book for the better part of the past year and was almost halfway through it now.

As Omar brought the hefty novel into his lap and flipped to the page he had left off at -

KNOCK! KNOCK! KNOCK!

A strong fist against the door; Omar jumped in his seat and cursed under his breath before snapping his book shut.

He cleared his throat and put on a chipper voice as he made his way to the door, "Coming!"

Omar opened the door only to be greeted by an armful of parchment and books, hiding the face of whoever carried them. Omar smiled, he knew this bundle of literature well.

"Faulor, welcome back." Omar greeted.

"No time, my friend!" Faulor shouted back through the pages and rushed in past Omar, "No time for trivial things!" Faulor was not only another silvery haired gentleman, but he was also a powerful and ancient wizard with knowledge beyond any mortals years (though, you couldn't tell in light conversation with him). He had notably longer locks than Omar and a fine short beard. He was wearing blue traveling robes and boots that had been well worn out.

"Trivial things such as greetings?" Omar laughed, watching as Faulor found the nearest open surface, in this instance the living room floor, and scattered the various books and papers in some sort of disorderly alignment.

"Precisely. Greetings, pleasantries, how-do-you-do's…"

"How *do* you do?" Omar asked, ignoring Faulor's hurriedness.

“Fine, thank you.” Faulor answered automatically, unbreaking his focus from the spread he had made and continued to flip through.

“You’re late, you know? You usually arrive sometime in the first week of the month.” Omar began, “What’s all this mess you’re making?”

“The world, Omar,” Faulor began dramatically, “it’s in danger.”

Scanning over the pages Omar could see many different languages and plenty of intimidating illustrations highlighting tall dark figures wielding what looked to be powerful weapons. A spear or a staff of some kind it looked like.

“I take it this danger has a name?” Omar leaned over Faulor’s shoulder to get a better look.

“Maelgrin. A queen determined to conquer the west. She intends to do so with this,” Faulor pointed to the spear-like weapon wielded by the figure, “The Witch's Lance.”

“*A lance!*” Omar scolded to himself, “I was close.”

“The *Witch’s* Lance,” Faulor corrected, “isn’t just a sportsman tool for jousting, it’s an ancient magic weapon once used by cruel demigods and corrupt rulers. It’s a powerful symbol among the western kingdoms, if they see her with it they will likely hand over their lands. And those who don’t…”

“Are doomed to perish, I imagine?” Omar nodded along.

“Precisely…” Faulor’s eyes narrowed as he stared at Omar, which Omar noticed after a moment.

“What are you looking at me like that for? I’m listening.”

“You’re listening like I’m telling you a story!” Faulor raised his voice.

“But you are telling me a story!” Omar defended, “Some semblance of one at the very least, and I tell you I’m listening! Maelgrin, the Witch’s Lance, the kingdoms in the west, and so on.”

“*And so on?!*” Faulor rose from the floor, “Since when did you get so carefree about the fate of the world? You’re sounding like you did when it was your first adventure!”

As Omar scrambled for words to explain himself Faulor paused to examine his friend and noticed things he hadn’t in his initial rush into the house, “When did you start wearing glasses, Omar?”

Omar set aside the excuses he had conjured, “Are you only noticing just now?”

“I am. Have I seen you without them before?”

“You might have if you visited more often.” Omar jabbed with foolhardy intent, but his words stung Faulor a bit. Faulor looked longer;

When Faulor had met Omar he was a younger man, thinner and gangly, like a young tree. Faulor saw promise in Omar and asked him to join a trek to the north with a shoddily arranged band of unsuspecting heroes. Faulor had convinced them to save the town's governor who was under the influence of a cursed necklace. Everyone made it out alive and swore they would never join Faulor on another adventure. Of course, they all broke this promise in time, Omar more proudly than the others. Faulor found Omar, once every half-year or so, and recruited him for whatever great and terrible danger faced the world and all its inhabitants. As these years and adventures passed, Faulor watched Omar grow bigger and stronger, a true stereotype of a noble hero. Together they were famous, unstoppable, and inspirational to everyone who knew their names and their stories. It was magnificent.

Now, before him, Faulor saw Omar as Omar saw himself. Gray and white hairs outnumbering the ones with color, tired skin beginning to sag and wrinkle, eyes beginning to glaze and posture beginning to stoop.

Faulor didn’t realize a look of melancholy had overtaken his face.

“Faulor,” Omar said gently, “I am old.” He gestured to himself.

“Old.” Faulor nodded, “My friend, when did this happen?”

“I suppose it was always happening.” Omar shrugged. “My back hurts more than it did a year ago. My eyes are more strained and my feet are sore, sorer than when we walked all those miles to Kellis and back. I’m afraid I would be more hindrance than help on any adventures you have for me, Faulor. I wish I could say otherwise, I’m sorry.”

Omar waited for a response but Faulor had slipped into upset silence.

“Oh, now don’t go pouting at me!” Omar shoved Faulor’s slouched shoulder, “I’m not *old* old! I’m just new old!”

“What on earth is ‘new old’?” Faulor asked.

“*Old* old means I’m dead. New old means I’ve started the last adventure, and I still have lots of time to find out what all I intend to do with it.”

Faulor smiled, “You made that up yourself, then?”

“Of course. I’m thinking of taking up poetry for a bit, I’ll need to start getting clever with my words.” Omar sat back on his velvet chair and gestured for Faulor to sit beside him for a while.

Faulor complied, “You were always clever with words, Omar. You’ll make an excellent poet.”

“I know.” Omar snapped, pretending to be insulted. The two burst out laughing.

“You realize you’ve put me in a rather difficult position. I’ve relied on you for decades now. Who can I task with something like this?” Faulor rubbed his forehead in stress, looking at the scattered papers.

“You know if you planned in advance you might have time to get your heroes in order before setting out on these dangerous ventures.” Omar raised an eyebrow.

“Don’t do that,” Faulor grumbled, “the passive-aggressive advice is for *old* old folks.”

“You did it to me!”

“I *am old* old!” Faulor chortled.

Omar rolled his eyes and smiled, “There’s a young woman on the outskirts of Aultur, named Ezilia. She’s the blacksmith's daughter and an incredible swordswoman, not to mention terribly eager to get out of town.”

Faulor nodded, considering, “You think she’s ready?”

“*I* wasn’t ready, Faulor. She’s as close as one can be, though.”

“And she’s good? Has the adventurer's spirit?”

“The strongest I’ve seen in some time. Trust me.” Omar reassured, looking to see Faulor moving his hand as though he was wiping away a tear.

Faulor cleared his throat, “Of course I trust you.”

“I should hope so.” Omar pat Faulor on his hand, “Now then, let’s clean this mess up so you can make it on *her* floor, hm?”

“Let’s.” Faulor agreed. Quickly, the two of them gathered together the papers and books. Omar lent Faulor a spare basket to help keep them together, which he happily accepted. In a few minutes, they were back at the front door. They both hesitated for a moment.

“Now, you keep her and yourself safe, as well as any others you might be taking with you.” Omar ordered.

“I always do.”

“And you’ll tell me all about it when you come back,” Omar added, “won’t you?”

Faulor squeezed Omar’s shoulder, “We’ll be back soon; and then we can all talk about our latest adventures. Won’t that be nice?”

Omar hugged Faulor, “It will be.”

They parted; Faulor left to find Ezilia, and Omar returned indoors to write some poetry to share with Faulor and Ezilia when they returned.